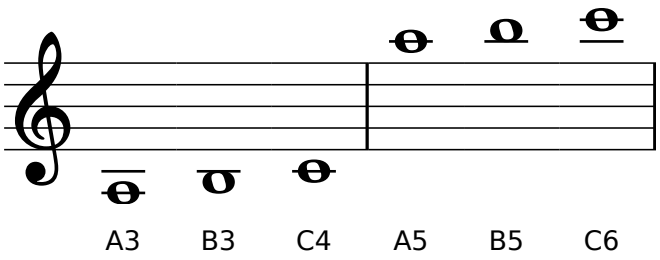
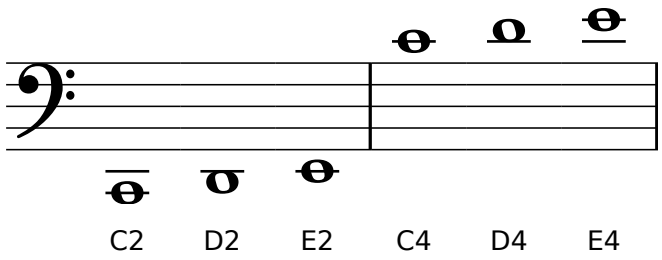
Ledger Lines and Octave Labels

Notes can go above or below a staff. A **ledger line** is a short line added above or below a staff for one note. Ledger lines are spaced like staff lines, so line notes and space notes continue in alphabetical order beyond the staff.



Treble clef: ledger notes below and above the staff



Bass clef: ledger notes below and above the staff

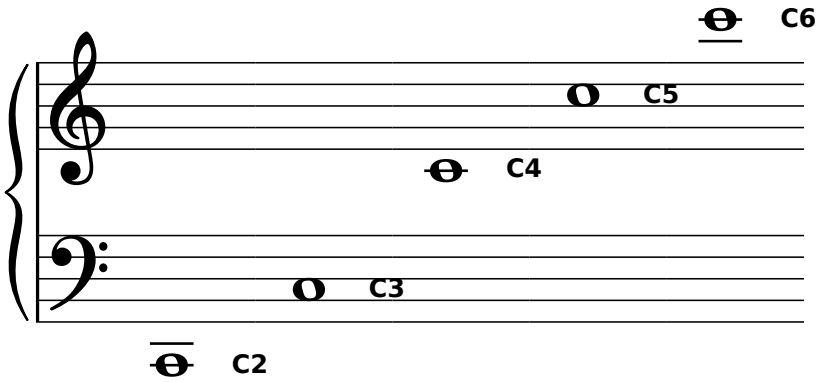
Middle C is written on one ledger line below the treble staff or on one ledger line above the bass staff. Both positions name the same key on the piano.

Octave labels

Each letter name appears in every octave, so a number is added to show which one. An **octave label** is a letter name followed by an octave number. This system is called scientific pitch notation.

- Middle C is C4.
- The octave number changes at each C. The notes from C4 up to B4 all have the number 4.
- The next C above B4 is C5. The B directly below middle C is B3.

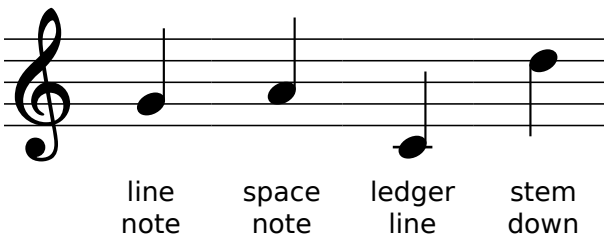
The lowest key on the piano is A0 and the highest is C8. This book uses the range from C2 to C6, shown below.



The five Cs from C2 to C6 on the grand staff.

Writing notes by hand

- Draw each notehead as an oval, a little wider than it is tall. A line note is centered on its line; a space note fills its space.
- Draw stems about one octave long: up on the right, down on the left.
- Space ledger lines like staff lines.



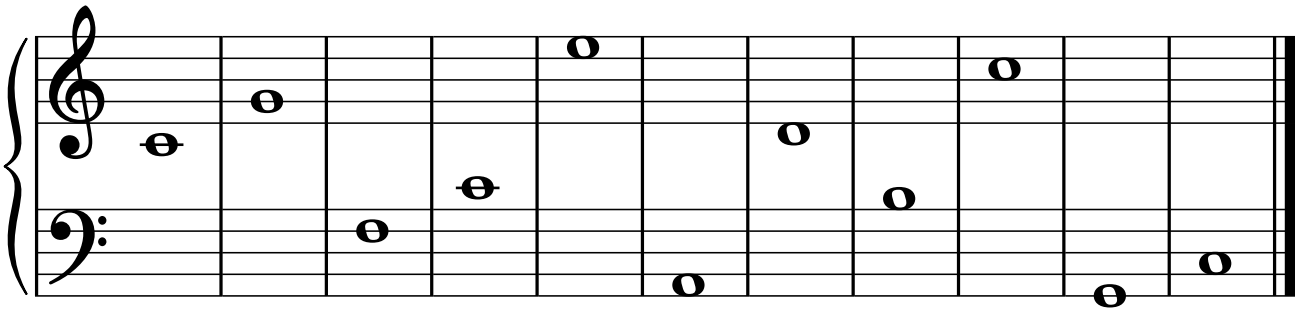
© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.

Name _____ Date _____

The Grand Staff and Ledger Lines

A. Notes on the grand staff Write the name and octave number of each note, such as C4.

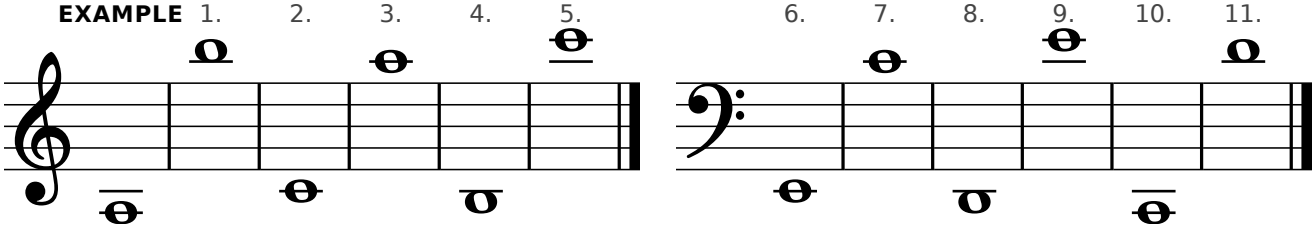
EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10.



C4 _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

B. Ledger-line notes Write the letter name and octave number of each note.

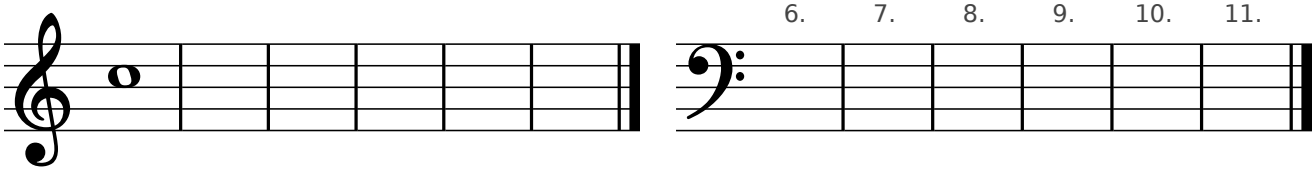
EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10. 11.



A3 _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

C. Write the notes Write each note as a whole note in the clef shown.

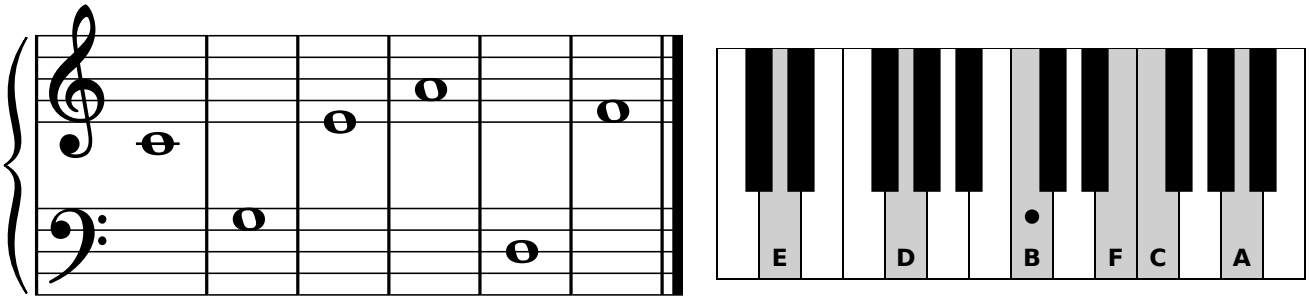
EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10. 11.



C5 A3 G5 C4 B5 D4 G3 C2 D4 A2 E2 C4

D. Match notes to keys Write the letter of the matching key. The dot marks middle C.

EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5.



B _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.